

ANI

TOUGH QUESTIONS Governor Acharya Devvrat at Gujarat Vidyapith

Over 250 families that have been living in the ashram for decades, including the direct descendants of people Gandhi had brought to his Harijan Ashram, face eviction and have been offered compensation to leave. In April this year, the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation razed 55 slum dwellings opposite the ashram.

The proposal to erect a towering statue of the Mahatma on the campus has also met with apprehension. "There has been more than one uncomfortable meeting over this issue," says a trustee of the ashram who does not wish to be named. "We already have one. Tall, intimidating statues do not sit well with Gandhi's ethos.

Initial resistance had come also from the five trusts that have managed the ashram for years: the Sabarmati Harijan Ashram Trust, the Sabarmati Ashram Preservation and Memorial Trust (SAPMT), the Sabarmati Ashram Gaushala Trust, the Harijan Sevak Sangh and the Khadi Gramodyog Samiti Trust. The SAPMT maintains the main ashram, which houses Hriday Kunj, where Gandhi lived. Though the trusts eventually came on board, there is apprehension that the Mahatma Gandhi Sabarmati Ashram Memorial Trust (MGSAMT), the body that the state government has formed for project execution and which comprises government officers, will eventually undermine all existing bodies.

To be honest, the ashram does need redevelopment. In a 2021 video statement explaining the purpose and outcome of the project, the authorities said the ashram used to be 120 acres originally. "Today, only five acres of that remains preserved.... The campus then had 65 buildings. Only three are open for visitors—the Hriday Kunj, the Magan Niwas and the Vinoba Kutir. The rest either lie in neglect or have been encroached upon," it said. "The project," says Patel, "is looking to develop only 55 acres of the original 120 acres by removing encroachments and giving visitors the real experience of what the ashram was like between 1917 and 1930. Old buildings will be carefully restored in a way that preserves the ethos of the original ashram." Exhibitions showing Gandhi's life and works will also be fused into the campus, it is learnt.

Patel believes the project will restore the ashram's sanctity. It is also not the first time that restoration has been proposed. "A similar plan was proposed 20 years ago and all trustees supported it," Patel adds. "For some reason, that didn't go through. This project is not doing anything new. It has been adjusted for the changes that have happened since."

SAPMT chairperson Kartikeya Sarabhai agrees that the restoration is a way to understand Gandhi's life. "Elaben [the late Ela Bhatt was the managing trustee of the ashram] had also agreed to the project on the condition that Bapu's message of simplicity will not be diluted and the families living on the premises not forced out but given alternative land within or outside the premises or monetary compensation."

KEY STICKING POINTS

The controversy at Gujarat Vidyapith

- Governor Acharya Devvrat's appointment as Chancellor sparks fears of a state takeover, leading to the resignation of nine of the 24 trustees. Their main contention? That Devvrat is not a 'Gandhian'
- Of the six people appointed to replace the nine trustees who quit, at least two are from the BJP
- Since the Vidyapith is now completely dependent on govt grants, trustees fear interference in Vidyapith's autonomy
- Earlier, in 2020, similar protests had erupted when Rajendra Khimani was appointed V-C without a UGC member being present on the selection committee